How has COVID-19 changed the way young people handle the distinction between the front and back stages, and how has this impacted social interactions and mental well being?

Introduction

The COVID 19 pandemic has been a metamorphic epidemiological event, completely altering the nature of social interaction in an instant. Sociologists must strive to come to understand these changes in order to fully address the wide spread and immensely important impacts that COVID-19 could have on things as complex as the management of public and private space to things as personal as mental health.

The boundaries between the front stage and back stage are extensively important to understanding social interactions and management during COVID-19. Goffman's dramaturgical framework differentiates between the frontstage - whereupon the individual performs social roles for an audience and the backstage, wherein the individual expresses themselves truly, free of public scrutiny or an audience (Goffman, 1959).

Before the pandemic, many youths navigated the boundaries between front stage and backstage behaviour with what one could term relative ease. COVID-19 flipped this significantly with the imposition of lockdown, social distancing and the mass shift towards remote life.

There has been a widespread change of how the home operates, previously as a private space more than a public one, now as a vessel for the “Goffmanian collapse” where the

distinctions between what is front stage and what is backstage have been completely realigned – “collapsing into each other” metaphorically speaking. Our study aims to explore how young people's behaviour shifted during the pandemic and as a result of lockdown, in a Goffmanian lens

Literature review

A thread in the studies identified in the literature view is the collapsing of the boundaries between work, home and leisure spaces during COVID-19 (Ülkeryıldız et al., 2020; Gao et al., 2022; Wardak et al., 2021). Gao et al. (2022, p. 31) points out that specific arrangement of boundaries "between work or school and home, and between leisure time and work time have been fundamentally blurred". Wardak et al. (2021) contextualise this change in the broader context of a "postdigital disruption of the concept of university as heterotopia" - the Foucauldian concept of a transformative institution that is delineating from the norm. Specifically, Wardak et al detail a process wherein COVID-19 has deeply altered and blurred the lines between formal university settings and the personal learning environments of students. Ülkeryıldız et al. (2020) expand on these lines too, stating that COVID 19 has not only collapsed the front stage-backstage distinction but that it has "accelerated our move to cyberworld -the online world". Pucino (2022) found that among staff at a community college in the Mid-Atlantic region, many found it hard to manage the boundaries and transition between work and home life due to the collapsing of the physical separation between them, with practices like long walks and meditation being coping strategies among those interviewed.

In terms of mental health, Williams et al. (2020) found that the loss of regular routine and daily structure led to profound psychological and emotional distresses, involving the "loss

of motivation, loss of meaning and loss of self-worth." As well as this, the loss of family members, of social interaction, and of income was considered significant. Interestingly, Kim and Florack (2021) found that regular social interactions pertaining to the COVID 19 pandemic were associated with decreased well-being and mental health. There was also a general decline in wellbeing and social trust associated with COVID-19 during the early stages of the pandemic. One could imagine the loss Williams et al. (2020) detailed, being associated with COVID 19, could account for the fact many have found it difficult to discuss COVID 19 with others, as Kim and Florack (2021) point out.

Sepang et al. (2022) explore the paradigm of digital dramaturgy in educational settings, revealing that simultaneous video conferences create a deeply fractured and fragmented self-presentation. The fragmentation distorts the relationship and conservation of differing front stage and backstage personas, creating identity strains and mental exhaustion. The researchers come up a neat idea, the concept of the "in-between region" in digital interactions, detailing the situation where people manage partial performances across the blurred spectrum of front and back regions concurrently. Pillai (2023) furthered details this process in the specific context of professional identities. They find that remote working and social isolation confused employees' work identities, creating a distorted disconnection from their roles and work colleagues. One thing is clear from all this, the Goffmanian collapse of COVID-19 has deeply thrown off the sense of identity of many.

This study will reach a gap in the research. The aim of this study is precision, to focus specifically on the experiences of young people during COVID-19, against the backdrop of the Goffmanian collapse detailed in the literature.

Data and methods

This study will rely on quantitative secondary data analysis. For this study, the dataset "Listen To Us! A Mixed-Methods Approach to Understanding Young People's COVID-19 Experience, 2021-2022" has been employed. The data was gathered through repeated cross-sectional studies over three waves. These methods of collection include interviews and self administered web-based questionaries using Computer-assisted web interviewing (CAWI). The dataset comes from a mixed method study of both quantitative and qualitative analysis, making it particularly suitable for our purposes. In addition, the study focuses on people aged between 13-25, which means it is relevant to assessing the COVID experiences of young people.

The sample size of the first wave is 2,077 participants, dropping to 148 and 89 for waves 2 and 3 respectively. As a result, we will only be employing the 1st wave for this study, as the sample sizes of waves 2 and 3 are too small. The large sample size of the first wave allows the dataset to be relevant to our study as it will capture a wider range of experience and point of views from young people during the pandemic. Due to only using wave one, we do miss out on the possibility of assessing changes over time, but such a goal would likely be too ambitious for this study.

Despite this limitation, the reliability of the first wave's dataset is ensured by its use of multi-stage stratified random sampling method. This creates a representative sample of the specific demographic this study is interested in. Table 1 presents the descriptive statistics of the wave one 2,077 participant study sample. The average age was 18.78 years (SD = 3.276) and the sample was skewed slightly towards women at 64.7% of the sample. For qualifications, the variable was recoded into three groups: 18.5% have a

degree or above, 58.5% have qualifications below a degree, and 22.9% have no qualifications.

Table 1. Sample Data

Variable	n (%)/mean (SD)	Missing data
Age	18.78 (3.276)	0
Gender		8
Women (%)	1,325 (64.7%)	-
Ethnicity		19
White	1,548 (75.5%)	-
Mixed/multiple	120 (5.9%)	-
Asian/Asian British	233 (11.4%)	-
Black/African/Caribbean/Black British	117 (5.7%)	-
Other	12 (0.6%)	-
Education		3
Degree or above	379 (18.5%)	-
Any qualification < degree	1,199 (58.5%)	-
No qualification	468 (22.9%)	-
Total sample size	2077	-

There are a number of drawbacks to the dataset used. Firstly, we have been only able to use wave 1 due to the declining sample size across the waves, as using wave 2 and 3, outside of their small samples, could possibly induce attrition bias, further harming the generalisability of using such small sample sizes. The reliance on CAWI could be taken to possibly limit participation to young people with internet access, excluding certain demographics and influencing the results. The sample is also notably skewed towards being more representative of women and white people, which could possibly influence the results. This is particularly significant when we consider that COVID-19 pandemic had a profoundly disproportionate impact on Black and Asian communities (Phiri et al., 2020).

This study will use four hypotheses to address our research question. For our first hypothesis, we state against the null hypothesis: availability of private space is positively associated with mental well-being during the pandemic for young people. The variables we include in this analysis are Private_Space_T1, (nominal, “Is there a place for some quiet time or for some privacy”) and SWEMWB_Total_Metric_T1, (Scale, total metric score for Short Warwick-Edinburgh Mental Well-Being). . For this hypothesis we use a Independent-Samples T-test. This will compare the means of the continuous variable between the two groups (those who do and those who do not have private space). Private_Space_T1 was recoded into two 1 = Yes/Sometimes and 0 = No.

Our second hypothesis states: There is a relationship between recent COVID-19 infection in the household and recent anxiety levels. For this test, there are two relevant nominal variables. COVID_Infection_1_T1, (“if you, or anyone in your home, had or currently has coronavirus”) and StayAtHome2_T1, (“As a consequence [of the pandemic] in the last two

weeks, I have felt anxious"). We conduct a chi-square test for this hypothesis to assess the association between two categorical variables.

Our third hypothesis is the most complex. It states: Increased anxiety about COVID-19 is positively associated with difficulties in maintaining social interactions. The relevant variables are COVID_Anxiety_T1, (scale variable, "How anxious are you about the coronavirus (COVID-19) pandemic?" (0-100)), and CYRM9_T1, (nominal, "I feel supported by my friends"). For this test, we employ a One-Way ANOVA with Tukey's HSD. This test will compare the means of anxiety scores across the five categories of perceived support from friends.

For the final hypothesis, we state: Difficulty dealing with remote work/schooling is negatively associated with professional identity stability. The variables involved are Working_From_Home_T1 ("How are you finding studying and/or working at home?") and CYRM3_T1 ("I know how to behave/act in different situations"), both nominal variables.

We conducted this test with a non-recoded and a recoded CYRM3_T1. Although the recoding yielded more simplified results, it also profoundly reduced degrees of freedom and cell counts, completely altering the p values. Therefore, we remained with the non-recoded results.

Results and discussion

Table 2 details the findings of the test for hypothesis one. Our t-test result shows a clearly statistically significant difference between the mental scores of those with and those without any private space. Individuals who had access to private space (coded as 1.00)

had a higher mean score (M = 19.67, SD = 3.695) on the Short Warwick-Edinburgh Mental Well-Being Scale compared to people without private space (coded as .00, M = 18.51, SD = 4.012). This difference is statistically significant (t(2032) = -3.399, p < .001). The Cohen's d effect size however was 0.314, implying a small to medium effect. This may imply that while there is a statistically significant association between the variables, other factors are likely to play into the nature of youth mental states during the pandemic, as implied in the literature. The mean difference of scale is 1.166. This means that those without private space are on average scoring 1.166 points lower on the scale than those with private space. This finding shows a rejection of the null hypothesis that there is no link between the variables.

Table 2, Hypothesis 1 (t-test)

Variable	Mean (SD)	t(df)	Sig. (Equal variances assumed, both two and one sided)	Cohen's d
Mental Wellbeing (Access to Private Space) n = 1909	19.67 (3.695)	-3.399 (2032)	< .001	-0.31
Mental Wellbeing (No Access to Private Space) n = 125	18.51 (4.012)			

Table 3 details the findings of the test for the 2nd hypothesis. The chi-square test of independence testing the relationship between recent COVID-19 infection in the household and anxiety over the last two weeks revealed a statistically significant association between the two variables, $\chi 2(3, N = 2004) = 41.183$, $p < .001$. Our table reveals this in the context of the chi-square counts. The table indicates a differential between the observed counts and the expected counts, which is consistent with a rejection of the null hypothesis. We can therefore say these findings support the hypothesis that recent COVID 19 in the household is associated with increased anxiety levels.

Table 3, Hypothesis 2 (chi-square)

Anxiety Level	No COVID-19 Infection (N = 1845)	COVID-19 Infection (N = 159)	Total
Not at all	208 (Expected: 216.4)	27 (Expected: 18.6)	235
Less than before	180 (Expected: 196.1)	33 (Expected: 16.9)	213
About the same	563 (Expected: 573.6)	60 (Expected: 49.4)	623
More than before	894 (Expected: 859.0)	39 (Expected: 74.0)	933
Stat.	Value		
Chi-Square (χ^2)	41.18		
Degrees of Freedom (df)	3		
N	2004		

p-value	< .001

Table 4 details the findings of the test for hypothesis three. Our hypothesis states: Increased anxiety about COVID-19 is positively associated with difficulties in maintaining social interactions. The results from the One-Way ANOVA test show that the F-value is 0.480 with a p-value of 0.750. Therefore, the null hypothesis has not been rejected. There seems to be no significant statistical association between COVID 19 anxiety and struggles with social interaction. The effect sizes go even further in supporting this. The eta-squared value is .001, epsilon-squared is -.001, and both omega-squared fixed-effect and random-effect values are -.001 and .000, respectively. These are tiny effect sizes and heavily suggest the there is very little association between COVID-19 anxiety levels and social interaction difficulties. The table does not detail the specific Tukey HSD post hoc results because there was no p value differences between the pairs, none.

Table 4, Hypothesis 3 (ANOVA)

One-Way ANOVA	**Value**
F-value	.480
p-value	.750
Effect Sizes	
Eta-squared	.001
Epsilon-squared	-.001
Omega-squared Fixed-effect	-.001
Omega-squared Random-effect	.000

Post Hoc Tests (Tukey HSD)	No significant differences between any group pairs
Homogeneous Subsets	
I feel supported by my friends	Subset for alpha = 0.05
A little (N=279)	61
Somewhat (N=516)	61.95
A lot (N=539)	62.32
Quite a bit (N=571)	62.81
Not at all (N=144)	64.31
Sig.	.491

Tables 5 and 6 shows the findings of the final hypothesis. The chi-square test was used to assess the relation between difficulties dealing with remote/schooling and professional identity stability. The results indicate a statistically significant association between these variables ($\chi^2(24) = 70.314$, $p < .001$). The actual counts differ across all various levels of difficulty and identity stability with their expected counts. For example, those reporting "extreme difficulty" with remote work and schooling are overrepresented in the "not at all" category of professional identity stability (actual count: 17, expected count: 9.6). However, young people finding remote work/schooling "Neither easy nor difficult" are underrepresented in the "Not at all" category (actual count: 15, expected count: 16.4) and overrepresented in the "Quite a bit" category (actual count: 134, expected count: 127.1).

Table 5, Final Hypothesis (chi-square)

Statistic	Value	df	p-value
Pearson Chi-Square	70.314	24	<.001
Likelihood Ratio	72.081	24	<.001
Linear-by-Linear Association	12.274	1	<.001

Table 6, Final Hypothesis (count table)

Working_From_Home_T1 (remote difficulties)	CYRM3_T1: (stability)					
	Not at All	A Little	Somewhat	Quite a Bit	A Lot	Total
Extremely Difficult	17 (9.6 expected)	33 (23.7)	52 (47.7)	53 (74.1)	125 (124.9)	280
Moderately Difficult	8 (13.2 expected)	36 (32.5)	71 (65.6)	111 (101.9)	159 (171.7)	385
Slightly Difficult	14 (15.9 expected)	43 (39.4)	66 (79.4)	136 (123.4)	207 (207.8)	466
Neither Easy nor Difficult	15 (16.4 expected)	29 (40.6)	102 (81.8)	134 (127.1)	200 (214.1)	480
Slightly Easy	9 (6.6 expected)	23 (16.4)	31 (33.1)	54 (51.4)	77 (86.5)	194

Moderately Easy	1 (4.7 expected)	4 (11.7)	15 (23.5)	31 (36.5)	87 (61.6)	138
Extremely Easy	6 (3.6 expected)	5 (8.8)	12 (17.7)	23 (27.5)	58 (46.4)	104
Total	70 (70)	173 (173)	349 (349)	542 (542)	913 (913)	2047

The pandemic has fronted a significant remoulding of the borders between Goffman's front and back regions for youth. Research has shown that this "Goffmanian collapse" has been the subject of much distress (Ülkeryıldız et al., 2020; Gao et al., 2022). This likely explains why our study has found that private space is associated with higher mental health scores. In the broader context of Goffman's work and the literature, it would be logical to assume that personal space during COVID helped deal with the stress involved in the breakdown of a clear distinction of back and front stages. Although of course, the modest effect size does imply that unseen confounding factors could play a role.

The positive association between recent COVID-19 household infection and anxiety over a two week period is consistent with the broader literature that ties together the pandemic and psychological harm, in particular with Williams et al's (2020) theme of loss, since it not only represents the anxiety of potentially losing ones family members, but also reinforces the loss of normal life in the context of a pandemic. In the general course of life, the lifeworld of many is made up of one’s immediate milieu and there is a general tendency for this to be what people see significant historical events through. This finding could indicate that COVID 19 in the household serves as an anxious factor within one’s lifeworld that reinforced the profound reality of COVID-19.

The one way-ANOVA showed no significant relationship between COVID-19 anxiety levels and perceived social difficulty. This finding could be interpreted as contradicting studies suggesting a general association between COVID-19 and disruptive social engagement (Kim & Florack, 2021, Sepang et al., 2022). In particular, the lack of an association between COVID-19 anxiety and feeling supported by friends could contradict Kim & Florack's (2021) finding of an association between COVID-19 and social distrust. However, it could also be taken to mean that COVID 19 anxiety simply doesn't impact the feeling of being supported by friends doing the pandemic and instead has impact across other areas.

Lastly, the association between difficulties managing remote work/schooling and the sense of knowing how to act in differing situations shows how the struggle to manage remote work or schooling has caused many to suffer a sense of alienation from regular social norms, becoming increasingly uncomfortable with how Goffmanian collapse has totally changed their day to day lives professionally. As Pillai (2023) observed, there has been a mass fracturing of the boundaries between back and front stages, which causes massive struggle in handling how COVID 19 has altered identity and shifted its manifestation in an increasingly digital context.

Conclusion:

This study further evinces the dramatic impact of COVID-19 on the already fragile life and existence of youth, especially across social interactive behaviours and mental wellbeing. The near total collapse of clear differentiation between boundaries of Goffmanian regions during COVID-19 has recast the sense of self and nature of social performance among young people. In inevitable future pandemics, ensuring private space for younger people is essential for their wellbeing and development. The potential association between recent

COVID-19 infections and increased anxiety shows the need for more comprehensive progressive policy for mental health systems.

The major strength of this study lay in the use of a secondary dataset with a large multi-stage stratified random sample dealing with the demographic of interest for our study. However, it faces a number of issues. White women are the majority composite of the sample and as such this will skew the results. This study has shown us that COVID 19 has had a profound impact on the lifeworld of many youths across the global. The Goffmanian collapse we saw during COVID-19 has resulted In many young people feeling a lack of stability in their professional identity and increases in anxiety levels.

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